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BOOK REVIEW

A Psychologist Experiences the Concentration Camp

*Viktor E. Frankl's *... trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen* or *Man's Search for Meaning* – A Rereading from Today's Perspective*

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ABSTRACT

Viktor E. Frankl's account of his experiences in National Socialist concentration camps was first published in Vienna in 1946 under the title "Ein Psychologe erlebt das Konzentrationslager" and later became known as "... trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen." In its English version, "Man's Search for Meaning," which was expanded by an introduction to logotherapy, the book is among the most widely read psychological works of the twentieth century. This review undertakes a rereading from the perspective of contemporary psychology. It first describes the structure and content of the book, in particular Frankl's account of the prisoners' psychological reactions in three phases and his reflections on inner freedom and meaning in extreme suffering. It then appraises the book's particular genre, situated between testimony, phenomenological description, and programmatic foundation of logotherapy. Critical points include the limits of generalizing from individual experience, the risk of retrospectively attributing meaning to survival, and the relationship of the book to other survivor testimonies. The review concludes that the work retains its significance as an existential document and as a point of departure for meaning-centered psychology, but should not be read as empirical evidence for the effectiveness of meaning orientation.

Keywords: Viktor E. Frankl · book review · concentration camps · logotherapy · inner freedom

ZUSAMMENFASSUNG

Viktor E. Frankls Bericht über seine Erfahrungen in nationalsozialistischen Konzentrationslagern erschien 1946 in Wien unter dem Titel „Ein Psychologe erlebt das Konzentrationslager" und wurde später unter dem Titel „... trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen" bekannt. In der englischsprachigen Fassung „Man's Search for Meaning", die um eine Einführung in die Logotherapie erweitert wurde, zählt das Buch zu den meistgelesenen psychologischen Werken des 20. Jahrhunderts. Die vorliegende Rezension unternimmt eine Relektüre aus der Perspektive der gegenwärtigen Psychologie. Sie beschreibt zunächst Aufbau und Inhalt des Buches, insbesondere Frankls Darstellung der psychischen Reaktionen der Häftlinge in drei Phasen sowie seine Reflexionen über innere Freiheit und Sinn im äußersten Leid. Anschließend wird die besondere Textgattung zwischen Zeugnis, phänomenologischer Beschreibung und programmatischer Grundlegung der Logotherapie gewürdigt. Kritisch diskutiert werden die Grenzen einer Verallgemeinerung individueller Erfahrung, die Gefahr einer nachträglichen Sinnzuschreibung an das Überleben sowie das Verhältnis des Buches zu anderen Zeugnissen Überlebender. Die Rezension kommt zu dem Ergebnis, dass das Werk seine Bedeutung als existenzielles Dokument und als Ausgangspunkt sinnzentrierter Psychologie behält, aber nicht als empirischer Beleg für die Wirksamkeit von Sinnorientierung gelesen werden sollte.

Schlüsselwörter: Viktor E. Frankl · Rezension · Konzentrationslager · Logotherapie · Innere Freiheit

1 The Work Under Review

Reviewed: Frankl, V. E. (1946). Ein Psychologe erlebt das Konzentrationslager. Verlag für Jugend und Volk; and the English-language edition Frankl, V. E. (2006). Man's search for meaning. Beacon Press. Since the late 1940s, the German-language version has appeared in numerous editions under the title *... trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen* ("... Saying Yes to Life in Spite of Everything").

Hardly any psychological book of the 20th century has found a comparable readership. By his own account, Frankl wrote the report within a few days of his return to Vienna, and it was originally meant to be published anonymously. That a scholarly journal should review this book some eight decades after its first publication requires justification: it is not only a historical document but, to this day, the first point of access to logotherapy for many people, and thus a text

whose readings shape the understanding of meaning-centered psychology.

The review follows the original German-language version and draws on the English-language edition insofar as it contains additional parts. Content is rendered in paraphrase; extensive verbatim excerpts are avoided.

2 Structure and Content

The core of the book is Frankl's account of his experiences as a prisoner. In 1942, Frankl was deported with his family to the Theresienstadt ghetto and later taken to Auschwitz and to subcamps of the Dachau concentration camp; his parents, his brother, and his first wife perished (Klingberg, 2001; Längle, 1998). Frankl largely dispenses with a chronological narrative and instead attempts to describe typical psychological reactions of the prisoners. He distinguishes three phases: the shock of admission; the phase of camp life proper, characterized by apathy, emotional blunting, and reduction to immediate survival; and the phase after liberation with its own difficulties, including feelings of depersonalization and bitterness (Frankl, 1946/2006).

Running through the description are reflections that later become basic ideas of logotherapy. Frankl emphasizes that even under extreme conditions a last freedom remains to the human being: the freedom to choose one's attitude toward the circumstances. He reports moments of inner turning toward loved ones, the significance of a task that awaits one, and fellow prisoners who gave others their last piece of bread. At the same time, he describes how the loss of any perspective on the future could undermine inner stability.

The English-language edition supplements the account with a brief introduction to the basic concepts of logotherapy and a later postscript in which Frankl sets out his position of "tragic optimism": the conviction that people can find meaning even in the face of suffering, guilt, and death (Frankl, 1946/2006).

Stylistically remarkable is the restraint with which Frankl speaks of himself. He usually describes his own experiences only insofar as they illustrate typical experiences and refrains from a detailed account of his own suffering. This restraint lends the text a peculiar matter-of-factness that many readers find particularly compelling.

The logotherapeutic part of the English-language edition is kept brief. It introduces concepts such as the will to meaning, the existential vacuum, noogenic neurosis, and paradoxical intention. Anyone wishing to become systematically acquainted with logotherapy must turn to Frankl's major professional works; as an introduction to Frankl's thought, however, this part serves its purpose.

3 Appraisal

The particular achievement of the book lies in its combination of testimony and psychological observation. Frankl writes as someone affected, but with the eye of a psychiatrist, and he strives for a language that does not accuse but seeks to understand. The depiction of psychological reactions to extreme stress is impressive in its precision, even if it cannot claim to be a systematic investigation.

For psychotherapy, what is significant above all is Frankl's insistence on a dimension of human freedom that persists even where external freedom is completely lacking. This idea is central to the later conception of attitudinal values and has influenced existentially oriented approaches far beyond logotherapy (Yalom, 1980). Contemporary research on meaning also frequently refers to the book as a starting point, although it now develops its concepts independently and tests them empirically (Wong, 2012).

Also noteworthy is the importance Frankl attaches to future orientation. He describes how fellow prisoners who had before their eyes a task or a person for whom they wanted to go on living found inner stability, and in this context he takes up Nietzsche's dictum that he who has a why to live can bear almost any how. These observations anticipate questions that were taken up in later research on hope, goal orientation, and meaning making under stress.

Didactically, the book is excellently suited as an entry point for courses on existential psychotherapy. It stimulates engagement with questions that are easily neglected in a curriculum focused on disorders and techniques: What remains to a person when almost everything has been taken from them outwardly? What role do attitude, relationship, and responsibility play in coping with extreme stress? In a seminar, such questions can be productively linked with contemporary research on meaning.

Not least, the book impresses with its linguistic clarity. Frankl largely avoids technical terminology and thereby reaches a readership far beyond the professional world. That a text matured under the most difficult conditions imaginable manages without pathos and nevertheless leads to profound questions is among the reasons for its lasting impact.

4 Critical Remarks

A rereading from today's perspective must at the same time point out limitations. First, the book is based on the experience and memory of a single individual. Frankl's descriptions of typical reactions are generalizations from personal observation; they can provide valuable hypotheses but cannot ground empirically established statements about the psychological consequences of extreme traumatization.

Second, there is the danger of a reading that attributes survival to an inner orientation toward meaning and thereby, conversely, suggests that those who were murdered lacked meaning or inner stance. Frankl himself contradicted this interpretation and emphasized that the best of us did not return (Frankl, 1946/2006). In his later reflections, Primo Levi forcefully highlighted the role of chance and external circumstances in survival (Levi, 1986). A responsible reading should include this perspective so as not to inadvertently establish a hierarchy between survivors and the murdered.

Third, the book should be read in dialogue with other testimonies. The accounts of Levi (1958) and the essays of Améry (1966) set different emphases and reveal that the experience of the camps eludes any unified interpretation. Precisely in contrast to them, it becomes apparent that Frankl's account is not only testimony but also the foundation of a therapeutic program – a dual function that should be kept consciously in mind when reading.

Fourth, attention must be drawn to the history of the book's reception. It is frequently quoted in self-help and motivational contexts in which individual sentences are detached from their context. Such a reception threatens to obscure the gravity of what is reported and to reduce Frankl's ideas to a formula of positive thinking. Frankl himself opposed any glorification of suffering and emphasized that avoidable suffering is to be eliminated.

Finally, it would be desirable to bring the psychological consequences of extreme traumatization that Frankl hints at for the period after liberation into closer dialogue with later psychotraumatological research. Frankl's descriptions of depersonalization, bitterness, and disillusionment after the return are among the less noticed, but psychologically particularly illuminating, passages of the book.

5 Conclusion

… trotzdem Ja zum Leben sagen (Man's Search for Meaning) remains a significant document of human self-assertion under extreme conditions and an indispensable starting point for understanding logotherapy. The book can be recommended without reservation for university study and continuing education, provided that it is read not as empirical proof of the efficacy of meaning orientation but as existential testimony and as a source of theoretical intuitions. In addition, readers should consult biographical accounts (Klingberg, 2001; Längle, 1998) as well as other testimonies of survivors in order to grasp the historical and human dimension of the text adequately.

For the Journal of Meaning-Centered Psychology, this rereading is at the same time a form of self-reassurance: it reminds us that the scientific study of meaning emerged from an existential experience that eludes any instrumentalization. Methodological rigor and respect for this origin are not mutually exclusive but mutually dependent.

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